

“The Public Health Information Gap: Lack of Accessible and Reliable Health Information”

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I. Introduction

At present, access to accurate and understandable health information is an important part of maintaining good health and preventing illness. However, many people continue to experience difficulties in accessing, understanding, evaluating, and applying health information. This problem can become more significant among individuals who have limited access to healthcare professionals, reliable digital resources, or understandable health information. In the Philippines, a national survey involving 2,303 Filipinos aged 15 to 70 found that 51.5% had limited health literacy, demonstrating that a substantial portion of the population experiences difficulty in dealing with health information (Tolabing et al., 2022).

The increasing use of digital technology provides an opportunity to address this public health information gap. Telehealth can allow healthcare professionals to provide consultations, health education, follow-up care, and referrals through digital communication platforms. According to the World Health Organization (WHO, 2024), telemedicine can improve accessibility to healthcare services, reduce waiting times, support follow-up care, and reduce certain healthcare costs.

This particular problem of limited access to reliable health information is important to address because misinformation, poor understanding of health information, and limited access to healthcare providers can contribute to inappropriate health decisions and delayed healthcare-seeking. In this proposal, the author seeks to detail and scope the problem of the public health information gap and outline an IT-enabled telehealth solution that can provide accessible, reliable, and understandable health information while connecting individuals with healthcare professionals.

II. Problem description

In modern times, people obtain health information from different sources, including healthcare professionals, websites, social media platforms, search engines, and online communities. Although digital platforms have made health information easier to access, not all information available online is accurate, reliable, or easy to understand. Individuals may encounter misinformation, complicated medical terminology, conflicting information, or sources that lack professional credibility. These barriers can make it difficult for people to determine which information should be trusted and applied to their health.

The problem is particularly evident in the Philippines. According to Tolabing et al. (2022), 51.5% of the 2,303 Filipino respondents included in the first national health literacy survey had limited health literacy. The study measured health literacy as the ability to access, understand, appraise, and apply health information in the areas of healthcare, disease prevention, and health promotion. The study also found that 45.94% of respondents had limited health literacy specifically in accessing health information.

Several factors contribute to this problem. These include differences in educational and health literacy levels, limited access to healthcare professionals, geographical barriers, digital literacy limitations, lack of reliable online resources, and the presence of misinformation. People living far from healthcare facilities may also experience difficulty obtaining immediate professional advice. In addition,

individuals with limited digital skills may struggle to navigate online health platforms or determine whether information comes from a credible source.

Low public health awareness and limited health literacy may affect how individuals make decisions regarding their health. People who have difficulty understanding or evaluating health information may be more vulnerable to misinformation, inappropriate self-care practices, or delayed healthcare-seeking. These problems can become more serious when individuals rely on social media or other unverified online sources instead of consulting qualified healthcare professionals.

However, simply providing more information online may not completely address the problem. Information can still be difficult to understand, and individuals may not know when professional consultation is necessary. Therefore, there is a need for an integrated digital system that does not only provide health information but also connects users with healthcare professionals who can provide appropriate guidance.

With this in mind, telehealth can serve as a technology-enabled approach to reducing the public health information gap. The WHO identifies telemedicine as a means of providing medical, diagnostic, and treatment-related services through telecommunications technologies when distance is an important factor. Telehealth can improve access to healthcare services, particularly for individuals who experience geographic or accessibility barriers (WHO, 2024).

III. Proposal solution

The proposed solution to address the public health information gap is the development of an integrated telehealth and digital health information platform. This system is designed to provide users with accessible, reliable, and understandable health information while allowing them to connect with qualified healthcare professionals through digital communication technologies.

One of the key features of the proposed system is a verified health information hub containing simplified information about common diseases, symptoms, prevention, medications, healthy practices, and when to seek professional care. Information presented on the platform can be based on credible sources such as the Department of Health (DOH), World Health Organization (WHO), and other recognized healthcare institutions. This feature can help users distinguish reliable health information from unverified online content.

Another major feature is telehealth consultation, which allows users to communicate with healthcare professionals through video consultations, messaging, or other appropriate digital communication methods. Users can describe their health concerns and receive professional guidance without immediately needing to travel to a healthcare facility. WHO has reported that telemedicine can contribute to shorter waiting times, improved follow-up and management of health conditions, reduced costs, and improved accessibility of healthcare services (WHO, 2024).

The platform can also include a digital referral system that directs users to appropriate healthcare facilities when concerns require physical assessment or services that cannot be provided through

telehealth. A health facility locator can help users identify nearby hospitals, clinics, rural health units, and other healthcare facilities. Additional features may include health reminders, public health announcements, vaccination information, emergency guidance, and multilingual content in Filipino and Bisaya to improve accessibility and comprehension.

The system primarily targets individuals who experience difficulties accessing reliable health information and healthcare services, particularly people in geographically isolated or underserved communities. It can also benefit students, working individuals, older adults, and other users who may prefer obtaining initial health guidance through digital platforms.

However, the proposed system should complement rather than completely replace face-to-face healthcare. WHO recommends that client-to-provider telemedicine complement in-person healthcare and operate with appropriate safeguards for patient safety, privacy, security, accountability, and data protection. Therefore, the platform should include secure user accounts, privacy protections, informed consent procedures, verified healthcare professionals, and clear instructions regarding situations that require immediate physical or emergency care.

The expected impact of this solution includes improved access to reliable health information, increased health literacy, easier communication with healthcare professionals, reduced barriers caused by geographic distance, improved healthcare navigation, and better awareness of appropriate health practices. Overall, integrating telehealth with a verified digital health information system provides a practical and scalable IT-based approach to reducing the public health information gap.

IV. Conclusion

The lack of accessible, reliable, and understandable health information remains an important public health concern, particularly when individuals experience difficulties accessing healthcare professionals or evaluating information obtained from digital platforms. The national health literacy survey in the Philippines found that 51.5% of surveyed Filipinos had limited health literacy, highlighting the need for interventions that make health information easier to access, understand, evaluate, and apply (Tolabing et al., 2022).

Addressing this problem requires more than simply increasing the amount of health information available to the public. Information must be reliable, understandable, accessible, and connected to appropriate professional guidance. This proposal highlights the development of a telehealth and digital health information platform as a technology-enabled solution to bridge these gaps.

By combining verified health information, online healthcare consultations, digital referrals, health facility information, and public health updates, the proposed system can help individuals make more informed health decisions and access healthcare services more conveniently. Telehealth can also help reduce barriers related to distance and accessibility while supporting healthcare professionals in providing remote services (WHO, 2024).

Ultimately, integrating telehealth technology with reliable digital health information can provide a sustainable approach to improving public health awareness and access to healthcare. Through responsible implementation, secure digital systems, and collaboration with healthcare professionals, the proposed platform can contribute to a more accessible, informed, and digitally connected healthcare environment.

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